

Usa Student Visa

- For citizens or lawful permanent residents of the United States (U.S.)
- If you're a citizen of the U.S., you have options for what you can show as proof of identity.
- If you're a lawful permanent resident of the U.S., you must travel with a valid green card (or equivalent official proof of status in the U.S.) and a valid passport from their country of nationality (or an equivalent document).
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- Show proof of funds Always required
- To support yourself and any family members coming with you, you must show proof of funds.
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- Write a letter of explanation Recommended
- Generally, foreign nationals who wish to travel to the United States must first obtain a visa, either a nonimmigrant visa for a temporary stay, or an immigrant visa for permanent residence. You must have a student visa to travel to the United States to study. Your course of study and the type of school you plan to attend determine whether you need an F visa or an M visa.
- Students cannot travel on the Visa Waiver Program or with Visitor Visas You must have a student visa (F or M visa) to travel to the United States to study. You may not study after entering on a visitor (B) visa, unless you are eligible for and have obtained a change of status from USCIS, or through the Visa Waiver Program (VWP), except to undertake recreational (non-credit) study as part of a tourist visit. For more information on the VWP, see Visa Waiver Program.
- For short periods of recreational study, a Visitor (B) visa may be appropriate A visitor (B) visa permits enrollment in a short recreational course of study, which is not for credit toward a degree or academic certificate. Learn more about Visitor Visas.
- Study leading to a U.S. conferred degree or certificate is not permitted on a visitor (B) visa, even if it is for a short duration. For example, a student in a distance learning program that requires a period of time on the institution's U.S. campus must obtain a student (F or M) visa prior to entering the United States.
- Student Acceptance at a SEVP Approved School The first step to studying in the United States is apply to a SEVP-approved school in the United States. If the SEVP-approved school accepts your enrollment, you will be registered for the Student and Exchange Visitor Information System (SEVIS) and must pay the SEVIS I-901 fee. The SEVP-approved school will issue you a Form I-20. After you receive the Form I-20 and register in SEVIS, you may apply at a U.S. Embassy or Consulate for a student (F or M) visa. You must present the Form I-20 to the consular officer when you attend your visa interview.
- If your spouse and/or children will live with you in the United States while you study, they must also enroll in SEVIS, obtain individual Form I-20s from the SEVP-approved school, and apply for a visa (but they do not pay the SEVIS fee).
- Visit the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) Student and Exchange Visitor Program (SEVP) website to learn more about SEVIS and the SEVIS I-901 Fee.
- Visit the Department of State EducationUSA website to learn about educational opportunities for undergraduate and graduate study, and an overview of the application process. You can also visit the DHS Study in the States school search page to search for SEVP-certified schools.
- How To Apply

- There are several steps to apply for a visa. The order of these steps and how you complete them may vary by U.S. Embassy or Consulate. Please consult the instructions on the embassy or consulate website.
- Complete the Online Visa Application
- Online Nonimmigrant Visa Application, Form DS-160 – Learn more about completing the DS-160. You must: 1) complete the online visa application, and 2) print the application form confirmation page to bring to your interview.
- Photo –You will upload your photo while completing the online Form DS-160. Your photo must meet the Photograph Requirements.
- Schedule an Interview
- Interviews are generally required for visa applicants with certain limited exceptions. Consular officers may require an interview of any visa applicant.
- You should schedule an appointment for your visa interview at the U.S. Embassy or Consulate in the country where you live. You may schedule your interview at another U.S. Embassy or Consulate, but be aware that it may be more difficult to demonstrate that you qualify for a visa outside of the country where you live.
- Wait times for interview appointments vary by location, season, and visa category, so you should apply for your visa early. Review the interview wait time for the location where you will apply:
- New Students – Student (F and M) visas for new students can be issued up to 365 days before the start date of a course of study. However, you will not be allowed to enter the United States on your student visa more than 30 days before the start date.
- Continuing Students - Student (F and M) visas for continuing students may be issued at any time, as long as the student is currently enrolled at a SEVP-approved school or institution and in SEVIS. Continuing students may enter the United States at any time before classes start.
- Prepare for Your Interview
- Fees - Pay the non-refundable visa application fee, if you are required to pay it before your interview. If your visa is approved, you may also pay a visa issuance fee, if applicable to your nationality. Fee information is provided below:
- Application Fee
- \$185
- Select your nationality to see Issuance Fee
- All Fees
- Review the instructions available on the website of the U.S. Embassy or Consulate where you will apply to learn more about fee payment.
- Gather Required Documentation
- Gather and prepare the following required documents before your visa interview:
- Passport valid for travel to the United States – Your passport must be valid for at least six months beyond your period of stay in the United States (unless exempt by country-specific agreements). Each individual who needs a visa must submit a separate application, including any family members listed in your passport.
- Nonimmigrant Visa Application, Form DS-160 confirmation page.
- Application fee payment receipt, if you are required to pay before your interview.
- Photo – You will upload your photo while completing the online Form DS-160. If the photo upload fails, you must bring one printed photo in the format explained in the Photograph Requirements.

- Certificate of Eligibility for Nonimmigrant (F-1) Student Status-For Academic and Language Students, Form I-20 or Certificate of Eligibility for Nonimmigrant (M-1) Student Status for Vocational Students, Form I-20 – Your school will send you a Form I-20 once they have entered your information in the SEVIS database. You and your school official must sign the Form I-20. All students must be registered in the Student and Exchange Visitor System (SEVIS). Your spouse and/or minor children, if they intend live in the United States with you, will each receive an individual Form I-20.
- Additional Documentation May Be Required
- A consular officer will interview you to determine your qualifications for a student visa, and may request additional documents, such as evidence of:
 - Your academic preparation, such as:
 - Transcripts, diplomas, degrees, or certificates from schools you attended; and
 - Standardized test scores required by your U.S. school;
 - Your intent to depart the United States upon completion of the course of study; and
 - How you will pay all educational, living and travel costs.
- Review the instructions for how to apply for a visa on the website of the U.S. Embassy or Consulate where you will apply.
- Attend Your Visa Interview
- A consular officer will interview you to determine whether you are qualified to receive a student visa. You must establish that you meet the requirements under U.S. law to receive a visa.
- Ink-free, digital fingerprint scans are taken as part of the application process. They are usually taken during your interview, but this varies based on location.
- After your visa interview, the consular officer may determine that your application requires further administrative processing. The consular officer will inform you if this is required.
- After the visa is approved, you may need to pay a visa issuance fee (if applicable to your nationality), and make arrangements for the return of the passport and visa to you. Review the visa processing times to learn more.
- Entering the United States
- A visa does not guarantee entry into the United States. A visa only allows a foreign citizen to travel to a U.S. port-of-entry (generally an airport) and request permission to enter the United States. The Department of Homeland Security (DHS), U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officials at the port-of-entry have authority to permit or deny admission to the United States.
- After you present your passport, visa, and Form I-20 at the port-of-entry, a CBP official will make this decision. Upon admission, the CBP official will provide an admission stamp or paper Form I-94, Arrival/Departure Record.
- Learn about procedures for students (with F or M visas) entering the United States on the CBP website under Arrival Procedures for Students or Exchange Visitors. Learn about admissions and entry requirements, restrictions about bringing food, agricultural products, and other restricted/prohibited goods, and more by reviewing the CBP website.
- Extending Your Stay
- Foreign students in the United States with F visas must depart the United States within 60 days after the program end date listed on Form I-20, including any authorized practical training.
- Foreign students may request an extension through U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) website (see the USCIS Extend Your Stay page). Additional information to maintain student status is on the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement SEVP website under Maintaining Your Immigration Status While a Student or Exchange Visitor.

- Failure to depart the United States on time will result in being out of status. Under U.S. law, visas of individuals who are out of status are automatically voided (Section 222(g) of the Immigration and Nationality Act). Any multiple entry visa that was voided due to being out of status will not be valid for future entries into the United States.
- Failure to depart the United States on time may also result in you being ineligible for visas in the future in certain cases. Review Visa Denials and Ineligibilities and Waivers: Laws to learn more.
- Change of Status
 - If your plans change while in the United States (for example, you marry a U.S. citizen or receive an offer of employment), you may be able to request a change in your nonimmigrant status to another category through U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS). See Change My Nonimmigrant Status on the USCIS website to learn more.
 - While you are in the United States, receiving a change of status from USCIS does not require you to apply for a new visa. However, once you depart the United States you must apply for a new visa at a U.S. Embassy or Consulate in the appropriate category for your travel.
- Additional Information
 - There is no guarantee you will be issued a visa. Do not make final travel plans or buy tickets until you have a visa.
 - For information about working in the United States during your study, review Students and Employment and Form I-765 Work Authorization Instructions on the USCIS website.
 - If you have a temporary break in your study, view the information on the SEVP website under Do Students Returning from Temporary Absences Need New Visas? If your student visa is still valid, but you are outside the United States, you should consult with your Designated School Officials.
- Spouse and children
 - Your spouse and unmarried, minor children who intend to reside with you during your study may apply for F-2 or M-2 visas. Although SEVIS fee payment is not required, your school must issue them an individual Form I-20, which is required to apply for their visas. You must provide a copy of your F-1 or M-1 visa and provide proof of relationship.
 - Your minor children are permitted to attend school in the United States while accompanying you.
 - U.S. Embassies and Consulates adjudicate visa applications for same-sex spouses in the same way that we adjudicate applications for opposite sex spouses.
 - A valid U.S. visa in an expired passport is still valid. Unless canceled or revoked, a visa is valid until its expiration date. If you have a valid visa in your expired passport, do not remove it from your expired passport. You may use your valid visa in your expired passport along with a new valid passport for travel and admission to the United States.
- Get a student visa to study in the U.S.
 - To study in the U.S. as an international student, you must get a student visa. Learn about the types of student visas, how to apply, and if you can work while you study.
- Types of student visas
 - F-1 and M-1 visas for full-time students
 - The most common student visas are F-1 and M-1.
 - F-1 visas are for full-time international students pursuing academic studies.
 - M-1 visas are for full-time international students pursuing vocational studies.
 - See the differences between F-1 visas and M-1 visas [PDF, 4.83 MB].
 - J-1 visa for exchange students

- The J-1 exchange visitor visa is for foreign nationals who have been approved to take part in work-and-study-based exchange programs. Examples include visiting scholars, camp counselors, au pairs, and research assistants. Learn about the educational programs that J-1 visa holders can participate in.
- Student visa requirements
- Before you plan to come to the U.S. to study as an international student, get a basic overview of how the process works. Your 5 steps to U.S. study covers:
 - Researching schools
 - Living and educational expenses
 - School applications
 - Student visas
 - Preparing to come to the U.S.
- International students who apply for an F-1 or M-1 visa must attend a school and enroll in courses that are certified by the Student and Exchange Visitor Program (SEVP).
- Search for SEVP-certified schools in the U.S.
- Learn what programs of study qualify for SEVP.
- Get a more detailed overview of what immigration processes and forms are required from the time you choose a school until you complete your studies.
- In June 2025, the U.S. Department of State announced changes to student and exchange visitor visas. Check your relevant embassy or consulate for application and appointment eligibility.
- How to apply for, extend, or renew a student visa
- Visit the Department of State's website to learn more details about F-1 or M-1 visas and J-1 visas. Get information about:
 - Eligibility rules
 - How to apply
 - Appointment wait times
 - Application fees
 - Extending your stay in the U.S.
 - Student visa renewals
- Can you work in the U.S. with a student visa?
 - If you have an F-1, M-1, or J-1 visa, you may be eligible to work in the U.S. But you may only qualify for work on-campus or at a job related to your studies.
 - Learn more about employment for students with F-1 and M-1 visas.
- J-1 visa holders must contact their responsible officer to find out if they qualify for work outside their program of study.
- Citizens of the United States of America, Australia, Canada, Israel, Japan, New Zealand, Switzerland, the Republic of Korea, as well as EU citizens may apply for their residence permit after entering Germany without a visa. However, please note that some German Aliens' Authorities require a prior visa application - even for the above mentioned citizens - due to an overload of residence permit applications and the unavailability of appointments. In cases where an employment is intended to begin directly after arrival in Germany (e.g. work, internship, research), a visa (which includes the work permit) has to be issued in advance, since it is not possible to start working in Germany before having the obligatory work permit.

- Student Visa General information: All persons who wish to study at a college or university in Germany are required to obtain a residence permit. In order to enter Germany, a student visa has to be issued. Once all required documents have been submitted, the application and supporting documents will be forwarded to the appropriate Aliens Authority (Ausländerbehörde) at the applicant's intended place of residence during his/her stay in Germany. The processing can take up to 12 weeks. As soon as the application has been approved by the German authority, the Embassy/Consulate will issue a national visa for the first 6 months of the intended stay. A final residence permit for a longer period (usually the first year of studies in Germany) will be issued upon arrival by the Aliens' Authority. Although the visa is called a "national visa", please note that it does also entitle its holder to enter other Schengen countries for a stay of up to 90 days for tourism purposes. Required documents: Please make sure to prepare two complete sets of the following documents collated in the order listed below and bring them to your appointment. Incomplete documentation may result in the rejection of your application. Valid passport – issued within the past 10 years, providing a minimum of 2 blank pages. Application form – duly and fully completed Declaration of accuracy of information Passport sized photos – no older than three months, must meet biometric standards Copies of the passport's data page Residence permit in the U.S., e.g. Visa, Green Card, US passport Proof of address, e.g. valid driver's license, utility bill, lease Letter of acceptance/enrolment issued by a German university Motivation letter Proof of housing in Germany incl. full address (e.g. rental agreement, hotel reservation or invitation letter in case of private accommodation with name, full address and passport copy of the inviting person) Proof of qualification for studying in Germany (e.g. former degrees/certificates) Proof of sufficient funds to cover the costs of your stay: - proof of scholarship for studies in Germany OR - blocked account: When applying for visa, you can provide evidence that you are able to meet your living costs by opening a blocked bank account. You have free choice of provider. Information on providers that offer this service worldwide is available on the Federal Foreign Office website OR - formal obligation ("Verpflichtungserklärung") If applicant is under the age of 18: birth certificate with parental information, original and official translation into German or English, if applicable (must be certified by a notary public if parent is not present at the interview) – plus one copy each consent letter signed by both parents (signature must be certified by a notary public if parent is not present at the interview) application form signed by at least one parent passport copies of both parents Proof of travel health insurance for the first 90 days of your stay with a minimum coverage of 30.000 EUR (see here for detailed requirements). The German missions in the US reserve the right to ask for additional documents at any time during the processing of your application whenever deemed appropriate. Presenting the aforementioned documents does not guarantee that a visa will be granted. Fees: The visa fee amounts to 75 EUR (for applicants under the age of 18: 37.50 EUR) and is payable in USD in cash only. Conversion into USD is made based on the exchange rate at the time of application. Additional information: This information sheet has been prepared with utmost care. It is intended to provide a point of reference to our clients but may not be fully applicable to every individual case. If you have further, more specific questions which are not answered by the information contained here nor on our website www.germany.info/visa, please contact the German Embassy/Consulate General serving your U.S. home state The German missions in the U.S. cannot accept any responsibility for inaccuracies contained in this information sheet. (January 2019)

Language Course Visa General information: All residents of the United States who wish to do a language course in Germany must obtain a residence permit in the form of a visa. Please note that a visa can only be granted for a so called "intensive language course" of at least 18 hours a week. Once all required documents have been submitted, the application and supporting documents will be forwarded to the competent Aliens Authority (Ausländerbehörde) at the applicant's intended place of residence during his/her stay in Germany. The processing can take up to 12 weeks. As soon as the application has been approved by the German authority, the Embassy/Consulate will issue a national visa for the first 6 months of the intended stay. A final residence permit for the whole duration of the language course will be issued upon arrival in Germany by the Aliens' Authority. Although the visa is called a "national visa", please note that it does also entitle its holder to enter other Schengen countries for a stay of up to 90 days for tourism purposes. Required documents: Please make sure to prepare two complete sets of the following documents collated in the order listed below and bring them to your appointment.

Incomplete documentation may result in the rejection of your application. Valid passport – issued within the past 10 years, providing a minimum of 2 blank pages. Application form – duly and fully completed Declaration of accuracy of information Passport sized photos – no older than three months, must meet biometric standards Copies of the passport's data page Residence permit in the U.S., e.g. Visa, Green Card, US passport Proof of address, e.g. valid driver's license, utility bill, lease Letter of acceptance/enrollment from a language school – must indicate the level (A1, B2, ...) and length of the course and weekly course hours. Motivation letter and school certificates/university degree Proof of housing in Germany incl. full address (e.g. rental agreement, hotel reservation or invitation letter in case of private accommodation with name, full address and passport copy of the inviting person) Proof of sufficient funds to cover the costs of your stay: - proof of scholarship for studies in Germany OR - blocked account: When applying for visa, you can provide evidence that you are able to meet your living costs by opening a blocked bank account. You have free choice of provider. Information on providers that offer this service worldwide is available on the Federal Foreign Office website. OR - formal obligation ("Verpflichtungserklärung") If applicant is under the age of 18: birth certificate with parental information, original and official translation into (January 2019) German or English, if applicable (must be certified by a notary public if parent is not present at the interview) – plus one copy consent letter signed by both parents (signature must be certified by a notary public if parent is not present at the interview) application form signed by at least one parent passport copies of both parents Proof of travel health insurance for the first 90 days of your stay with a minimum coverage of 30.000 EUR (see here for detailed requirements). The German missions in the US reserve the right to ask for additional documents at any time during the processing of your application whenever deemed appropriate. Presenting the aforementioned documents does not guarantee that a visa will be granted. Fees: The visa fee amounts to 75 EUR (for applicants under the age of 18: 37.50 EUR) and is payable in USD in cash only. Conversion into USD is made based on the exchange rate at the time of application. Additional information: This information sheet has been prepared with utmost care. It is intended to provide a point of reference to our clients but may not be fully applicable to every individual case. If you have further, more specific questions which are not answered by the information contained here nor on our website www.germany.info/visa, please contact the German Embassy/Consulate General serving your U.S. home state The German missions in the U.S. cannot accept any responsibility for inaccuracies contained in this information sheet.